

Third, because the upstream is testing the interaction of their software with other pure upstream releases, arbitrary changes downstream create problems in those interactions with other packages used in the downstream distribution. Every change begets more changes, and the result is a rapidly accelerating cycle of bugs and resulting patches, none of which are likely to be accepted upstream. So once you get on that treadmill, it's very difficult to get off without harming the users and the community.

Q What's the role of the Fedora Project Board, and you, as its chairman?

We have a Board with five community-elected members and four members appointed by Red Hat, who make policy decisions for the project as a whole. We document our mission and meetings through our wiki

page at fedoraproject.org/wiki/Board

One of my jobs is to chair the Fedora Board, and ensure that the governance of Fedora is working as smoothly as possible. I also am the person responsible for choosing the people who will fill the seats reserved for appointment by Red Hat. We turn over roughly half the seats on the Board after each Fedora release, so that there is always a chance for the community to make informed decisions about the leadership of the Project.

I always try to respect the need for balancing different constituencies on the Board, so these appointments are not limited to Red Hat employees. Last election cycle, for instance, I appointed Chris Tyler, a professor at Seneca College in Toronto and a long time Fedora community member, to the Board, which has proved to be an excellent choice. This flexibility goes hand in hand with the

"We ensure Red Hat is a good open source citizen"

An interview with Max Spevack, the man responsible for managing the Community Architecture team, which makes sure Red Hat plays fair with the FOSS community.

Q Max, the last time you spoke to LFY was after the release of Fedora 7, when you were the Fedora Project Leader and that release in itself was an ambitious task, considering the merger of Core and Extra. Now, a year and a half later, a period in which we saw three more Fedora releases, what all do you think has changed? What were the important things you had in mind back then, and how many of those set goals have been achieved?

For me, Fedora 8 was about two main things. The first was maintaining Fedora's innovative trends, while giving the new infrastructure a chance to settle down and get polished. This also included nurturing along the idea of Fedora Spins, which the infrastructure changes and the Core/Extras merge enabled.

The second major thing that I was doing during the Fedora 8 timeframe was working internally with Red Hat to lay out a plan for the future organisation of Fedora. I was ready to step aside as Fedora Project Leader, and when we sat down and inventoried all of the responsibilities that I had acquired over the past two years, we agreed that it would be useful to do three things. First, hire a successor for the Fedora Project Leader (FPL) role (this turned out to be Paul Frields). Second, create an official Fedora Engineering Manager role (this turned out to be Tom Callaway), and third, set up an official Community team within Red Hat, which is the role that I took on.

During Fedora 9, my primary contribution was in

helping to ensure a smooth transition as Paul Frields came into the Fedora Project Leader role and joined Red Hat. We officially changed jobs about halfway through the release cycle, and I wanted to make sure that I gave him the same kind of help that Greg DeKoenigsberg gave to me when I started as Fedora Project Leader.

Simultaneously, of course, Greg and I were putting together the Community Architecture team, and figuring out the ways that it did, and did not, intersect with Fedora. I'll talk more about that later.

Q So, now that you're in charge of the Community Architecture team, how does this role differ from that of being an FPL?

The primary difference between the Community Architecture team and the Fedora Project is the recognition that while Fedora may be Red Hat's *most successful* community endeavour, it is by no means the *only* place where Red Hat interacts with the open source community.

The Community Architecture team is responsible for Red Hat's global community development strategy, leveraging the talent and abilities of the free software



Max Spevack